

Polish B1 State Exam: Comprehensive Preparation Report

Egzamin certyfikacyjny z języka polskiego jako obcego — poziom B1

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1. Exam Overview

What Is This Exam?

The **State Certificate Examination in Polish as a Foreign Language** is administered by the *Państwowa Komisja ds. Poświadczania Znajomości Języka Polskiego jako Obcego*, overseen by **NAWA** (Polish National Agency for Academic Exchange). The B1 certificate is legally required for:

- Polish citizenship applications

- EU long-term residence permits

Official website: certyfikatpolski.pl

Structure at a Glance

The exam spans **two days** (typically Saturday written + Sunday oral):

DAY	MODULE	DURATION	POINTS	TASKS
Day 1	Listening (Rozumienie ze słuchu)	30 min	30	5
	Reading (Rozumienie tekstów pisanych)	40-45 min	30	4-5
	Grammar (Poprawność gramatyczna)	45 min	30	8
	Writing (Pisanie)	75 min	30	2
Day 2	Speaking (Mówienie)	15 min (+5 min prep)	40	3
TOTAL		~210 min	160	

15-20 minute breaks between Day 1 modules.

Key Facts

- **Passing threshold:** 50% in **each** module independently (no cross-compensation)
- **Certificate validity:** Permanent (no expiry)
- **Cost:** up to 150 EUR (exam) + 20 EUR (certificate issuance)
- **Results:** 2-4 months after the exam
- **Everything is in Polish** — no English instructions on the exam

2. Section-by-Section Breakdown with Examples

2.1 Listening (Rozumienie ze słuchu)

PARAMETER	VALUE
Duration	~30 minutes
Tasks	5
Points	30
Pass minimum	15 points (50%)

Task Types

TASK	FORMAT	PLAYED	DIFFICULTY
1	Short utterances → multiple choice (a/b/c): identify speaker, meaning, or context	ONCE	Hard
2	Short dialogues → multiple choice (a/b/c)	Twice	Medium
3	Longer monologue/interview → true/false (TAK/NIE)	Twice	Medium
4	Four speakers' opinions → matching speakers to statements	Twice	Medium
5	Match utterances to photographs	Twice	Easy

Example (Task 1)

You hear a short announcement. You must choose where you might hear it:

- a) w sklepie (in a shop)
- b) na dworcu (at a station)
- c) w szpitalu (in a hospital)

Warning: Task 1 is the very first thing on the entire exam, played only once, and is considered a notorious trap by test-takers. Practice it extensively.

2.2 Reading (Rozumienie tekstów pisanych)

PARAMETER	VALUE
Duration	40-45 minutes
Tasks	4-5
Points	30
Pass minimum	15 points (50%)

Task Types

- **Multiple choice** (a/b/c) — read text, select correct answer
- **True/False** (TAK/NIE) — evaluate statements against the text
- **Matching** — connect titles/headings with text fragments
- **Text completion** — fill in missing words/phrases
- **Text reconstruction** — arrange fragments into logical order

What Texts Look Like

Sources include adapted newspaper articles (e.g., *Gazeta Wyborcza*), popular science texts, and practical documents (announcements, ads, signs). All are culturally neutral and adapted to B1 vocabulary.

Candidate insight: Reading is consistently rated the easiest section. Both bloggers who shared scores achieved 90-100%. But don't skip practice — "the actual test may be harder than expected."

2.3 Grammar (Poprawność gramatyczna)

PARAMETER	VALUE
Duration	45 minutes
Tasks	8
Points	30
Pass minimum	15 points (50%)

The 8 Tasks in Detail

TASK	WHAT IT TESTS	FORMAT
1	Noun, adjective & pronoun declension	Select correct forms from options
2	Conjunctions (spójniki)	Fill in from a word box (one distractor)
3	Comparative/superlative adjectives & adverbs	Select correct forms
4	Verb tenses: present & future	Write correct forms from given infinitives
5	Question formation	Form questions about underlined sentence elements
6	Sentence transformation	Rewrite sentence using a provided word
7	Verb aspect & mood (imperative, conditional)	Select correct verb forms
8	Prepositions (przyimki)	Fill in from a word box (one distractor)

Examples

Task 5 — Question Formation:

Sentence: "Marek zrobi zakupy **jutro**." (jutro underlined) Answer: "**Kiedy** Marek zrobi zakupy?"

Task 6 — Sentence Transformation:

Original: "Byliśmy w teatrze." + word: *do* Answer: "Poszliśmy **do** teatru."

Task 2 — Conjunctions (word box):

Box: *że / oraz / ale / chociaż / czyli / ani / więc* "Lubię kawę, ___ nie piję jej wieczorem." → **ale**

Essential Grammar Topics at B1

CATEGORY	WHAT YOU MUST KNOW
Cases	All 7 cases for nouns, adjectives, pronouns, numerals (singular + plural)
Verbs	Present, past, future (simple + compound), conditional, imperative
Aspect	Perfective vs. imperfective distinction (dokonany vs. niedokonany)
Motion verbs	iść/chodzić, jechać/jeździć
Comparison	Adjective and adverb comparative/superlative forms (including irregular: duży→większy, dobry→lepszy)
Prepositions	Correct case government (do + Gen, na + Acc/Loc, w + Loc, z + Gen/Instr)
Pronouns	Personal, possessive, demonstrative, interrogative, indefinite, negative
Syntax	Complex sentences with: że, żeby, bo, więc, ale, ani, chociaż, ponieważ, dlatego
Impersonal	można, warto, trzeba, należy
Verb government	potrzebować + Gen; myśleć o + Loc; wybierać + Acc

Universal consensus: Grammar is the **hardest** section. One candidate rated it 10/10 difficulty, barely passing at 50%. Even language professionals admit uncertainty about passing it.

2.4 Writing (Pisanie)

PARAMETER	VALUE
Duration	75 minutes
Tasks	2 texts (from 1 chosen set of 3)
Points	30
Pass minimum	15 points (50%)

Format

- Choose **1 set** out of 3 available

- Each set has **Text A** (short) + **Text B** (long) — you must write **both**
- Everything is **handwritten**

Text A — Short Form (25-50 words)

TYPE	POLISH	EXAMPLE PROMPT
Holiday greetings	Pozdrowienia	Write a postcard from your vacation in Italy
Wishes	Życzenia	Write birthday wishes to your Polish friend Ania
Invitation	Zaproszenie	Invite colleagues to a barbecue at your house
Announcement	Ogłoszenie	Write an ad for selling your apartment
Congratulations	Gratulacje	Congratulate a friend on their wedding

Text B — Long Form (150-175 words)

TYPE	POLISH	EXAMPLE PROMPT
Informal letter	List nieformalny	Write to a friend about your vacation in your home country
Formal letter	List formalny	Write a complaint about hotel service
Review	Recenzja	Write a review of a book/film you recently read/saw
Essay	Rozprawka	"Internet jest niezbędny w dzisiejszym życiu" — present arguments for and against
Description	Opis	Describe a person particularly close to you
Account/Report	Sprawozdanie	Describe a difficult situation and how you handled it

Structure Requirements

Essay: Introduction (wstęp) → Development with arguments (rozwiniecie) → Conclusion (zakończenie)

Letter: Greeting (Drogi/Droga... or Szanowny Panie...) → Body → Closing (Z pozdrowieniami / Z poważaniem) → Signature

10% word margin applies — slightly over/under won't lose points, but significant deviation will.

2.5 Speaking (Mówienie)

PARAMETER	VALUE
Duration	max 15 minutes
Preparation	~5 minutes
Tasks	3
Points	40 (highest-weighted section!)
Pass minimum	20 points (50%)

The 3 Tasks

Task 1 — Photo Description (0-7 points) Describe a photograph in detail: people, actions, setting, emotions.

Useful phrases:

- "Na zdjęciu widzę..." (In the photo I see...)
- "Na pierwszym planie..." (In the foreground...)
- "Na drugim planie..." / "W tle..." (In the background...)
- "Z lewej/prawej strony..." (On the left/right side...)
- "Osoba na zdjęciu wygląda na..." (The person looks...)

Task 2 — Monologue on a Given Topic (0-7 points) Express opinions or describe something. Example topics:

- "What are effective methods for learning foreign languages?"
- "Describe a person particularly close to you. Justify your choice."
- Advantages of city vs. countryside life
- Your dream vacation

Task 3 — Dialogue with Examiner (0-6 points) Role-play scenarios. Examples:

- Call a language school to inquire about courses and pricing
- Call a sick friend to offer help with shopping
- Make a complaint at a hotel
- Arrange a meeting with a colleague

Important: Determine whether the scenario requires **formal** (Pan/Pani) or **informal** (ty) register.

Scoring Breakdown (40 points total)

CATEGORY	POINTS
Task 1 completion	0-7
Task 2 completion	0-7
Task 3 completion	0-6
Grammar accuracy	0-8
Vocabulary & style	0-8
Pronunciation & fluency	0-4
Total	40

Candidate insight: Examiners are consistently described as **friendly** and supportive. The stress comes from nervousness, not from the examiners. **Never stop talking**, even if making errors.

3. Scoring & Passing Criteria

Points Summary

MODULE	MAX POINTS	PASS MINIMUM (50%)
Listening	30	15
Reading	30	15
Grammar	30	15
Writing	30	15
Speaking	40	20
Total	160	80

Critical Rule

You must score at least 50% in EVERY module independently. Failing even one module = failing the entire exam. A 100% in reading cannot compensate for 49% in grammar.

4. Difficulty Ranking — What Real Candidates Say

Based on blog posts, forum discussions, and language school reports:

RANK	SECTION	CONSENSUS	EVIDENCE
1 (Hardest)	Grammar	Universally the hardest	Rated 10/10 by one candidate, barely passed at 50%. Even Polish language professionals express doubt about passing.
2	Writing	Second hardest	Challenges: handwriting unfamiliarity, Polish punctuation rules (rarely taught), knowing <i>what</i> to write (not just grammar).
3	Listening (Task 1)	Notorious trap	Played once, first thing on the exam. Rest of listening is manageable.
4	Speaking	Manageable	Examiners are friendly. Stress comes from nerves, not difficulty.
5 (Easiest)	Reading	Consistently easiest	90-100% scores common among prepared candidates.

Real Candidate Scores

Candidate 1 (Mexican, 7 years in Poland — [Chido-Fajny blog](#)):

SECTION	SCORE
Listening	87%
Reading	90%
Grammar	50% (barely passed)
Writing	67%
Speaking	90%

Candidate 2 (2 months focused prep — [Polonization blog](#)):

SECTION	SCORE
Listening	90%
Reading	100%
Grammar	79%
Writing	88%
Speaking	100%

Notable Quotes from Forum Discussions

"Some of the questions are real toughies, even for Poles." — PolishForums user

"A2 to B1 is a huge jump." — Forum respondent

"I'd be hard pressed to say whether I'd pass it or not." — Experienced language professional

"For a lot of Polish native speakers, the test could be a challenge." — Polish language teacher

5. Preparation Recommendations

5.1 Overall Strategy

1. **Take a diagnostic test first.** Download a free sample test from [certyfikatpolski.pl](#), do it under timed conditions, and identify weak spots. Aim for 70%+ before booking the exam.
2. **General lessons are NOT enough.** Every successful candidate stresses that exam-specific preparation is essential. The exam has specific formats and time constraints that require dedicated practice.
3. **Budget minimum 50 hours** for exam-specific preparation (on top of your existing B1 knowledge).

4. **Use free official materials first** before buying textbooks. The certyfikatpolski.pl website has complete sample exams with audio and answer keys.
5. **Practice writing by hand** — many candidates haven't handwritten anything in years, even in their native language.
6. **The 90/10 rule** (from exam prep instructor): "My help is 10%, your independent work is 90%."

5.2 Section-Specific Strategies

Listening

- **Drill Task 1 relentlessly** — it's played once and it's the first thing on the exam
- Tasks 2-5 are played twice and described as "fairly simple"
- Listen to Polish radio, podcasts, and TV regularly to build speed comprehension
- Recommended podcast: *Polski Daily Stories*, *Pozdrowienia z Polski*

Reading

- Practice even if it feels like your strongest skill — "the actual test may be harder than expected"
- Read adapted newspaper articles (*Gazeta Wyborcza* level)
- Practice all task types: multiple choice, TAK/NIE, matching, text reconstruction

Grammar

- **Focus areas:** all 7 cases, verb aspects, comparatives/superlatives, conditionals, prepositions + case governance
- "There's no getting around it" — drill repeatedly
- The hardest subtask: choosing the correct tense AND writing the properly conjugated form
- Do official sample grammar sections multiple times

Writing

- **Don't try to master all text types** — focus strategically on recurring ones:
 - Short form: wishes (życzenia), greetings from vacation (pozdrowienia)
 - Long form: review (recenzja), informal letter, essay (rozprawka)
- Learn the **required structure** for each type (each has specific formatting requirements)
- Memorize key connectors: *po pierwsze*, *po drugie*, *z jednej strony*, *z drugiej strony*, *moim zdaniem*, *podsumowując*
- Practice counting words — know what 50 and 175 words look like in your handwriting

- Use YouTube channel "**Pozdrowienia z Polski**" for writing templates

Speaking

- **Practice with another person** — this is not optional
- Photo description template: describe who, what, where, then give your opinion (~1 min describing + time for commentary)
- Always determine formal (Pan/Pani) vs. informal (ty) register for Task 3
- Speak slower when nervous — it reduces mistakes
- Remember: examiners are friendly, the introductory small talk is not graded, and **never stop talking**

5.3 Timeline & Study Plan

If Already at B1 Level (Exam-Specific Prep)

WHEN	ACTION
3-4 months before	Confirm target exam date, check registration schedule
2-3 months before	Register immediately when slots open — they fill in minutes!
2 months before	Start daily structured preparation (30-60 min/day minimum)
6 weeks before	Work through sample exams systematically, join a prep course
3-4 weeks before	Full mock exams under timed conditions, focus on weak areas
1 week before	Final mock exam, light review, no cramming
Day before	Stop studying — avoid mental overload

If Coming from A2

Budget **6-12 months** of regular study before exam-specific prep begins.

If Starting from Zero

Approximately **350-500 hours** of study (CEFR estimate for Polish). Realistic timeline: **~2 years**.

Daily Study Routine (Final 2 Months)

- **Mon/Wed/Fri:** Grammar drills (20 min) + Writing practice (30 min)
- **Tue/Thu:** Listening exercises (20 min) + Reading practice (20 min)
- **Sat:** Full mock exam section under timed conditions

- **Sun:** Speaking practice with a partner/tutor
- **Daily:** 15 min vocabulary with Anki/flashcards

5.4 Exam Day Tips

1. **Stop studying the day before** — avoid mental overload
 2. **Arrive early** — registration can be slow with 130+ candidates
 3. **Bring:** passport, 2+ non-erasable pens (black/blue), water, snacks
 4. **Expect everything in Polish** — zero English on the exam
 5. **Phones are collected** at the door
 6. **Reset mentally** between sections — use the 15-20 min breaks
 7. **Don't panic about grammar** — even native speakers find it hard. Focus on getting 50%+
 8. **Never stop talking** during the speaking section, even if making errors
 9. **Count words** during writing — or know what your target looks like in your handwriting
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6. Resources & Materials

6.1 Textbooks

Exam-Specific (Ranked by Usefulness)

TITLE	WHAT IT IS	BEST FOR
Zdaj się na polski!	Comprehensive 120+ hour coursebook with 22 lessons	Full exam preparation
Polski na B1	161 tasks in 7 sample exams	Mock exam practice
Pisz po polsku!	Dedicated writing preparation with templates	Writing section
Bądź na B1	Task collection with sample tests (~30 PLN)	Budget practice
B1 — Piszę, mówię i zdaję!	Written + oral expression forms	Writing & speaking
MÓWIENIE — 40 przykładowych zestawów (PDF)	40 sample speaking sets	Speaking section
Wzornik krótkich form pisemnych (PDF)	~100 examples of short written forms	Short writing forms
Testy na 4 pory roku	Mock exams in official format	Timed practice

General B1 Textbooks

TITLE	NOTES
Hurra!!! Po polsku 3	Direct B1 exam preparation, communicative approach
POLSKI krok po kroku 2	Popular A2→B1 series, has online platform
Z polskim na ty	Grammar systematization

Where to Buy

- [Księgarnia Poltax](#) — specialist Polish-as-foreign-language bookshop
- startpolish.pl

- e-polish.eu / GLOSSA

6.2 Online Platforms & Apps

Exam-Specific

RESOURCE	WHAT IT OFFERS	COST
Polingo	Real past exams in original format with explanations	Paid
ProPolski Tests	Free online B1 grammar exercises with instant scoring	Free
e-polish.eu	9,000+ materials, smart flashcards, multimedia dictionary	Paid (12-month access)
Język Polski — B1 & B2 app (iOS, Android)	Simulated exam format with explanations	Free/Paid

General Polish Learning (Useful for B1)

APP	BEST FOR	NOTES
Busuu	CEFR-aligned B1 practice, community feedback	Best general app for B1
Babbel	Structured grammar instruction	Strong through B2
Anki	Vocabulary retention via spaced repetition	Free (desktop), many shared B1 decks
Quizlet	Pre-made B1 exam flashcard sets	Free

YouTube & Podcasts

CHANNEL/PODCAST	FOCUS
Pozdrowienia z Polski (YouTube)	#1 recommended — writing templates, grammar explanations
Hello Polish! Podcast	Writing section, PDF companions
Swojski język polski	General exam preparation
Polski Daily Stories	Listening practice for intermediates
Gadam po Polsku	Thematic vocabulary (~15 min episodes)

6.3 Courses

COURSE	FORMAT	PRICE	NOTABLE
Easy Polish	Online, max 6 students, Zoom	—	Small groups, mock exam included
VARIA	4 weeks online, 16 lessons	1400 PLN	Includes exam spot + fee
Together School	4-6 weeks, 2-3x/week	—	Accredited exam center
Vitas School	50 hours, max 8 people	—	Online + in-person
MEC Szczecin	Stationary/online hybrid	—	Course + exam package

6.4 Free Official Materials

RESOURCE	URL
Complete B1 sample test (2019)	PDF
B1 sample test (2020)	PDF
Past exam papers (Feb 2024)	PDF
Past exam papers (Apr 2024)	PDF
Past exam papers (Jun 2024)	PDF
Listening task collection	PDF
Reading task collection	PDF
Grammar task collection	PDF
Writing task collection	PDF
Speaking task collection	PDF
Free government textbook (B1-B2)	gov.pl
All past exams archive	certyfikatpolski.pl

7. Registration & Logistics

2026 Exam Dates

SESSION	DATES
1	February 14-15
2	April 25-26
3	June 27-28
4	October 17-18
5	December 5-6

Registration Warning

Spots fill within MINUTES of opening. The Polonization blogger reported all spots gone by 13:34. Some centers report slots disappearing in under 4 minutes.

- Registration opens **~2 months** before the exam
- Monitor your chosen center's website closely
- Some schools bundle exam spots with prep courses (guaranteed spot)
- If you miss registration, the next session may be months away — and also full

Costs

ITEM	AMOUNT
Exam fee (adults, B1)	up to 150 EUR (~700 PLN)
Certificate issuance (if you pass)	20 EUR (~100 PLN)
Youth exam (14-17)	90 EUR

What to Bring

- Valid passport
- 2+ non-erasable pens (black or blue ink)
- Water
- Snacks (6+ hour exam day)

8. Alternative: TELC Exam

Since 2023, **TELC Polish B1-B2** is recognized for EU long-term residence (but **NOT** for Polish citizenship).

FEATURE	STATE EXAM	TELC
Grammar	8 tasks, 45 min standalone section	Only 2 grammar tasks
Writing	Multiple format types, handwritten	Semi-formal email only
Results	2-4 months	4-5 weeks
Registration	Extremely competitive	More available
Recognized for	Citizenship + EU residence	EU residence only
Level	B1 only	B1-B2 in one sitting

If you need the certificate only for EU long-term residence (not citizenship), TELC may be a faster and less grammar-intensive path.

9. Sources

Official

- certyfikatpolski.pl — Official Exam Website
- [NAWA](#) — Certification
- [Official Sample Tests](#)
- [UMCS](#) — Exam Structure

Personal Accounts & Blogs

- [Chido-Fajny](#) — My Experience with the Polish Certification Exam
- [Polonization](#) — How to Pass the Polish B1 Exam
- [Elemelingua](#) — My Journey with Learning Polish

Language School Guides

- [Vitas School](#) — 11 Popular Questions About B1

- [Vitas School — Advice from the Lecturer](#)
- [Easy Polish — 3 Myths About the B1 Exam](#)
- [VARIA — Everything About B1 Certificate](#)
- [Hello Polish — Section Guides](#)
- [Pozdrowienia z Polski — B1 Preparation](#)
- [Prolog Publishing — Remarks on B1 Exam](#)

Forums

- [PolishForums — Preparing for B1 Exam](#)
- [PolishForums — B1 Certificate](#)

General Guides

- [CareersInPoland — 10 Questions About Certificate Exams](#)
- [Talk Polish — What You Need to Know at B1](#)
- [Residence Angels — Polish Language Exam Guide](#)